Scientists May Have Found a Lost Roman City in Austria

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Along the Danube River in Austria, researchers may have found an entire Roman city lost for nearly 2,000 years. The area was part of the Danube Limes, the Roman Empire's **frontier** along the river, part of which is now a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Since 2015, a team from several fields has studied a roughly six-mile stretch of **frontier** between the towns of Enns and St. Pantaleon-Erla, in what was once the northern border of the Roman province of Noricum.

Geophysical surveys revealed a previously unknown city near the hamlet of Stein. It covered about 62 to 74 acres and was carefully planned, with a grid of streets like a modern city's. Its most impressive feature was an **amphitheater** that could seat about 8,000 spectators. The city appears to have been founded next to a military **garrison** around 80 C.E. and abandoned about a century later. Researchers found no signs of destruction, so residents probably left in an orderly way.

Could this be Claudivium, a city mentioned by second-century geographer Claudius Ptolemy? The new site fits the coordinates Ptolemy gave, and a river he described flowing in from the north could be the Aist, which joins the Danube nearby. The name Claudivium also disappears from historical records after about 180 C.E., around when this city was abandoned.

Over three years, archaeologist Mario Wallner of GeoSphere Austria and colleagues scanned the site with ground-penetrating radar and **magnetometry**, mapping buried roads that cannot be seen from the surface. About 640 coins have been recovered, and a large cemetery lies to the northwest.

Why leave a thriving city? After Emperor Marcus Aurelius died in 180 C.E., his son Commodus signed a peace treaty ending the Marcomannic Wars. Rome then reorganized its **frontier** defenses, concentrated forces at nearby Lauriacum, and gave up the settlement at Stein. Similar tools and clothing pins found at Lauriacum suggest craftspeople moved there. The identification remains uncertain, however, because no **inscription** bearing the name Claudivium has been found.

Word Treasure

frontier -- The border area at the edge of a country's or empire's territory.

amphitheater -- A large round or oval open-air building where crowds watched performances or contests.

garrison -- A group of soldiers stationed in a place to defend it, and the place where they are based.

magnetometry -- A scanning method researchers used to map buried features of the site.

inscription -- Words carved or written on a hard surface, such as stone.

Background you need

The Danube Limes was the Roman Empire's frontier along the Danube River, guarding the northern border of provinces such as Noricum.

Roman frontier settlements often grew up next to a military garrison and were carefully planned, with streets laid out in a grid.

Archaeologists can study buried cities without digging them up by scanning the ground with tools such as ground-penetrating radar and magnetometry.

A second-century geographer named Claudius Ptolemy mentioned a city called Claudivium, and researchers are testing whether this newly mapped site could be that lost city.

Break it down

LEAD: Researchers may have found an entire Roman city lost for nearly 2,000 years along the Danube in Austria.

KEY EVENT: Geophysical surveys revealed a planned city near Stein with an amphitheater seating about 8,000.

+- WHO: A team from several fields, including archaeologist Mario Wallner and colleagues

+- WHEN: The city appears founded around 80 C.E. and abandoned about a century later

EVIDENCE: The site fits Ptolemy's coordinates for Claudivium, about 640 coins were recovered, and similar items at Lauriacum suggest craftspeople moved there.

OPEN QUESTION: No inscription bearing the name Claudivium has been found, so the identification remains uncertain.

Why it matters

Finding a whole planned city helps historians understand how Rome defended and organised its frontier. It also shows how scanning tools can reveal buried history without disturbing the ground.

Test what you remember

1. Near which hamlet was the previously unknown city found?

- (A) St. Pantaleon-Erla
- (B) Stein
- (C) Enns
- (D) Lauriacum

2. About how many spectators could the city's amphitheater seat?

- (A) About 180
- (B) About 62
- (C) About 8,000 spectators
- (D) About 640

3. When does the city appear to have been founded, and beside what?

- (A) In the second century, beside a river port
- (B) Around 180 C.E., beside a cemetery
- (C) Around 80 C.E., next to a military garrison
- (D) In 2015, next to a modern town

4. Which geographer mentioned the city that this site might be?

- (A) Claudius Ptolemy, who mentioned Claudivium
- (B) Mario Wallner
- (C) Commodus
- (D) Marcus Aurelius

5. Why did Rome give up the settlement, according to the article?

- (A) Residents were forced out by a river flood
- (B) It was destroyed in war
- (C) Archaeologists cannot guess
- (D) After Marcus Aurelius died, Commodus signed a peace treaty ending the Marcomannic Wars and Rome reorganized its frontier defenses, concentrating forces at nearby Lauriacum

6. Why does the identification as Claudivium remain uncertain?

- (A) No inscription bearing the name Claudivium has been found
- (B) The streets were not planned
- (C) The site is not near the Danube
- (D) No coins were recovered

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. The researchers: The researchers suggest the site could be Claudivium because it fits Ptolemy's coordinates, while noting the identification remains uncertain because no inscription with that name has been found.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):